

In Terry Pratchett's *Discworld* series, **most of the gods do not play chess; they throw dice.**

However, **Fate plays chess**, and he famously plays with **two queens** on his side of the board.

The full iconic quote from the novel *Interesting Times* explains the rule of the game:

text

"Most of the gods throw dice but Fate plays chess, and you don't find out until too late that he's been using two queens all along. Fate wins."

How the Discworld Gods Actually Play

While chess requires strategic planning, Sir Terry Pratchett notes that Discworld gods generally lack the mindset for it.

- **Lack of Imagination:** As noted in *Wyrd Sisters*, gods do not play chess because "*they haven't got the imagination*".
- **Vicious Games:** They prefer simpler games where mortals go straight to oblivion. A god's idea of true amusement is described as "*Snakes and Ladders with greased rungs*."
- **The Board:** When the gods do play games on Dunmanifestin (the mountain of the gods), they play with the lives of men on a board that maps directly to the entire world.
- **The Lady vs. Fate:** In books like *The Colour of Magic*, the gods gamble using dice. The goddess known only as **The Lady** (the personification of luck) regularly plays against **Fate**, using the famously unlucky wizard **Rincewind** as her primary pawn.

Who Else Plays Chess on the Disc?

While the gods stick to rolling dice and cheating, **Death** is the character who explicitly plays chess. He frequently plays against mortals who challenge him in an attempt to win back their lives, though Death usually wins because he always remembers how the knight moves.

If you are thinking of a specific cosmic game between entities, would you like to explore **Death's chess matches**, or read more about **The Lady and Fate's ongoing poker game** with the universe?

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Ah! If we switch from *Discworld* to Scott Meyer's **Magic 2.0 series** (starting with *Off to Be the Wizard*), the dynamic changes completely because **there are no actual gods—only hackers pretending to be wizards**.

If you travel back to medieval England in the Magic 2.0 universe, you are essentially a "god" compared to the mortals because you can alter the computer file that runs reality. In this series, the "wizards" (hackers) spend a massive amount of time **playing games and messing with each other**, treating their cosmic power like an absolute joke.

Here is how the "gods" play games in the *Magic 2.0* universe:

- **They Aren't Playing Chess, They're Playing *Paranoia*:** Unlike the grand strategy of chess, the wizards in Leadchurch live in constant fear of being out-hacked or pranked by each other. They don't play structured cosmic games with mortals; they spend their time programming macros to automate chores, making themselves look taller, or conjuring fake food.
- **The "Villains" Act Like Cheap Cheaters:** When a hacker like **Jimmy** (from the later books) or the original antagonist decides to play "god," they don't play strategic chess with human destinies. They use the reality file to treat mortals like video game NPCs, altering the database out of pure spite or boredom.
- **The "Wizard Chess" Subversion:** While series like *Harry Potter* feature literal, dangerous "Wizard Chess", *Magic 2.0* subverts this. The wizards *could* program a giant, living chess game, but they are generally too lazy or too busy arguing about pop culture, hiding from the modern government, and trying not to accidentally delete themselves from existence.

If you are thinking of a specific moment where the characters use their computer commands to simulate a game or mess with someone's mind, let me know the details! I can break down the exact programming trick Martin or Phillip used.

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The trope of deities playing a "**Cosmic Chess Game**" using mortals as pawns appears in several famous fantasy and sci-fi book series.

Depending on the specific tone you remember, it is highly likely one of these major series:

1. *The Belgariad* by David Eddings (Most Famous Example)

In this classic 5-book epic fantasy series, the entire plot is driven by **two opposing "Purposes" (cosmic, god-like consciousnesses) playing a massive game of destiny**.

- **The Chess Connection:** The characters are explicitly described as literal chess pieces in a cosmic match.
- **The Pieces:** Garion is the Child of Light (the white king's pawn that promotes to a king), Belgarath is the Eternal Man (the wizard/bishop), and Torak is the Dragon God (the opposing king).

2. *The Book of Swords* by Fred Saberhagen

In this series, **the gods forge 12 magical Swords of Power and scatter them among humanity.**

- **The Chess Connection:** The gods do this purely for their own entertainment, treating the human wars fought with these ultimate weapons as a massive **cosmic board game.**
- **The Twist:** The gods get a taste of their own medicine when the humans realize the game is rigged and use the swords to fight back against the deities.

3. *Animorphs* by K.A. Applegate

If it was sci-fi/young adult, this is the definitive cosmic chess match.

- **The Chess Connection:** Two god-like, immortal entities—**The Ellimist** (good) and **Crayak** (evil)—are locked in a cosmic stalemate. Because their raw power would destroy the universe if they fought directly, they agree to a strict set of rules where they can only influence events through small, proxy "pawns".
- **The Pieces:** The Ellimist chooses the Animorphs, while Crayak uses the parasitic Yeerks.

4. *The Eternal Champion / Elric of Melniboné* by Michael Moorcock

In this massive, interconnected dark fantasy multiverse, the overarching conflict is between the **Lords of Law** and the **Lords of Chaos**.

- **The Chess Connection:** These deities constantly fight for cosmic balance, using mortal champions (like Elric, Corum, or Hawkmoon) as mere pieces on a multiversal game board.

5. *Xanth* by Piers Anthony (Specifically *The Source of Magic*)

In this lighthearted, pun-heavy fantasy series, the characters discover a massive meta-twist.

- **The Chess Connection:** The entire magical land of Xanth and all of its inhabitants are actually just a simulation/game board being played by two massive, god-like **Demons** (Demon X(A)NTH and Demon C(H)AOS).

Do any of these specific setups—like the **12 Magic Swords**, the **Animorphs alien war**, or **Garion's prophecy** in *The Belgariad*—ring a bell for the book you are trying to find?

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You are remembering **the very first chapters of *The Colour of Magic***! Your memory is spot-on—the gods are introduced at the very beginning of the book doing exactly this.

The Cosmic Game in *The Colour of Magic*

While Terry Pratchett later clarified in his famous quote that "*Fate plays chess*", in this first novel, he describes the cosmic board game as a **literal mashup of chess, dice, and a world map**.

Right at the start of the book, we see the deities gathered in their mountain home, Dunmanifestin, playing a game called **The Game of the Gods**:

- **The Board:** The board is a perfectly detailed map of the Discworld.
- **The Pieces:** The game pieces are real people. The goddess **The Lady** (Luck) and **Fate** are playing against each other. Fate's piece is a powerful, brave hero, while The Lady's chosen pawn is the completely useless, cowardly wizard **Rincewind**.
- **The Gameplay:** They roll dice and strategically slide their pieces across the map. When Fate thinks he has Rincewind trapped in a corner to be killed, The Lady rolls a perfect, impossible number on the dice, allowing Rincewind to miraculously escape.

Why it feels like *Magic 2.0*

It makes total sense that your brain blended this with Scott Meyer's *Off to Be the Wizard!*

- In *The Colour of Magic*, the gods look down on mortals like pieces on a board or characters in a simulation, altering reality on a whim.
- In *Magic 2.0*, the hackers do the exact same thing—they look at the world file on their computer screens, treating real people like lines of code or video game assets.

Are you trying to track down a specific scene involving **Rincewind escaping from a monster** in that first book, or did you want to dive back into **how the *Magic 2.0* hackers manipulate reality?**

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